

ANALYSIS OF THE PRESENT

General overview

This document describes the present through public and verifiable data. Economic, demographic, social, institutional and environmental phenomena are intertwined and cannot be understood as watertight compartments. The analysis concentrates above all on what does not work, because that is where the need for an alternative arises; progress is not denied: it is reported alongside the critical issues, theme by theme. These advances are real and documented by the same sources; several of them, however, are slowing down. Every figure gives its source and year of publication. Estimates and projections are indicated as such; the last part is a reading of the data, not a datum.

Part one — The data

1. Inequality, poverty and hunger

- **Concentration of wealth:** The richest 10% of the world population owns about **75% of wealth**; the poorest half about 2% (World Inequality Report 2026). The wealth of billionaires reached **18,300 billion dollars** in 2025: +16% in one year, +81% since 2020 (Oxfam, 2026).
- **Extreme poverty:** Between 1990 and 2022 about **1.5 billion people** escaped it, but the reduction has almost come to a halt: in 2022 **838 million people** were still living on less than 3 dollars a day, 10.5% of the world population, and the estimate for 2025 is 9.9% (World Bank, 2025).
- **Hunger:** In 2025 about **645 million people** suffered from hunger, **7.8%** of the population: it was 8.6% in 2022, and this is the third consecutive year of decline. In Africa it affects one person in five. **2.69 billion** cannot afford a healthy diet (FAO and other UN agencies, SOFI 2026).
- **Housing:** In the EU, between 2010 and the beginning of 2025 house prices rose by **57.9%** and rents by 27.8% (Eurostat, 2025). Worldwide, about 2.8 billion people lack adequate housing and 318 million are homeless (UN-Habitat estimates, 2025).

2. Work

- **Work and wages:** More than **2.1 billion workers** out of 3.6, almost 58%, are employed informally, without protections (ILO, 2026). In high-income countries, between 1999 and 2024 productivity grew by 29% and real wages by 15% (ILO, Global Wage Report 2024-25).
- **Technology and employment:** **25% of world employment**, and 34% in high-income countries, is in occupations exposed to generative AI. What is expected is above all a transformation of tasks: complete replacement remains limited (ILO estimate, 2025).
- **Exploitation and child labour:** In 2021 **50 million people** were living in conditions of modern slavery, 10 million more than in 2016 (ILO, IOM and Walk Free estimate, 2022). In 2024, **138 million children** were working, 54 million of them in hazardous activities: more than **20 million fewer** than in 2020 (ILO and UNICEF, 2025).

3. Population, health and education

- **Population:** 8.2 billion people in 2024; expected peak of about **10.3 billion** in the mid-2080s (UN projection, World Population Prospects 2024). In OECD countries, the number of people aged over 65 per 100 of working age will rise from **33 in 2025 to 52 in 2050**, putting pensions and welfare under pressure (OECD projection, Pensions at a Glance 2025).
- **Life expectancy:** **73.3 years** in 2024, after the fall to 70.9 during the pandemic (UN, World Population Prospects 2024).
- **Child mortality:** Between 1990 and 2024 it fell by **60%**: from 93.5 to 37.4 deaths under five per 1,000 births, that is from one child in 11 to one in 27. Even so, in 2024 **4.9 million children** under five died, and since 2015 the pace of reduction has slowed by more than 60% (UN IGME, 2026).
- **Maternal mortality:** Reduced by **40%** between 2000 and 2023 (WHO and other UN agencies, 2025).
- **Health workforce:** A shortage of **11 million health workers** is projected by 2030, above all in low- and lower-middle-income countries (WHO projection).
- **Loneliness and mental health:** One person in six suffers from loneliness, with more than **871,000 deaths a year** associated with it (WHO, 2025). One adolescent in seven has a mental disorder (WHO).
- **Education:** In 2024 **273 million children and young people** were out of school, a number rising for the seventh consecutive year (UNESCO, 2026).

4. Essential services and the digital sphere

- **Water and sanitation:** **2.1 billion people** lack safe drinking water and 3.4 billion lack safe sanitation (WHO and UNICEF, 2025).
- **Electricity and cooking:** **92%** of the world population has electricity; 655 million people are still without it, and about 2 billion cook with polluting fuels (Tracking SDG7, 2026).
- **Digital:** 6 billion people, about three quarters of the world population, use the Internet; **2.2 billion** are still offline (ITU, 2025). 87% of respondents identify AI-related vulnerabilities as the fastest-growing cyber risk (WEF, Global Cybersecurity Outlook 2026).

5. Climate, energy and environment

- **Climate:** 2025 was **1.44 °C** warmer than the pre-industrial average; the last eleven years are the warmest ever recorded (WMO, 2026). CO₂ emissions from fossil fuels reached a record **38.1 billion tonnes** in 2025 (Global Carbon Budget 2025 estimate). With current policies, warming will reach 2.8 °C by the end of the century (UNEP projection, Emissions Gap Report 2025).
- **Clean electricity:** In 2025 renewables (**33.8%**) overtook coal (33.0%) for the first time in world electricity generation, and generation from fossil sources did not grow (-0.2%) (Ember, 2026). 692 GW of renewables were installed, 85.6% of new capacity (IRENA, 2026).
- **Climate adaptation:** Developing countries will need **310-365 billion dollars a year** by 2035; in 2023 they received 26, that is 12-14 times less (UNEP, Adaptation Gap Report 2025).
- **Planetary boundaries:** **Seven out of nine** have been exceeded, all with a worsening trend; the latest is ocean acidification (Planetary Health Check 2025).
- **Biodiversity:** Monitored populations of wild vertebrates declined on average by **73%** between 1970 and 2020 (WWF, Living Planet Report 2024). More than 48,600 species are threatened with extinction, 28% of those assessed (IUCN, Red List, 2026).
- **Forests:** Deforestation fell from 17.6 million hectares a year in the nineties to **10.9 million** in 2015-2025 (FAO, 2025).
- **Ozone:** More than **99%** of the substances that deplete it have been eliminated; the layer will return to 1980 levels around the middle of the century (WMO, 2025).
- **Resources and waste:** The extraction of materials rose from 30 billion tonnes in 1970 to about **106 billion** in 2024 (UNEP, Global Resources Outlook 2024). In 2022, **1.05 billion tonnes of food** were wasted, 19% of that available to

consumers (UNEP, Food Waste Index 2024). Every year 92 million tonnes of textile waste are produced (UNEP, 2025).

6. War, security and forced displacement

- **Conflicts:** In 2025 there were **65 armed conflicts** involving at least one State, the highest number since 1946, and about 244,600 deaths from organised violence (UCDP, Uppsala University, 2026).
- **Military expenditure: 2,890 billion dollars** in 2025 (+2.9%), the eleventh consecutive year of growth. It is 2.5% of world GDP, the highest level since 2009 (SIPRI, 2026).
- **Nuclear weapons:** In January 2026 there were about **12,187 warheads** in existence; those in military stockpiles numbered about 9,745, 130 more in one year (SIPRI Yearbook 2026).
- **Forced displacement:** At the end of 2025 the people forced to leave their homes numbered **117.8 million**, one in 70 worldwide. It is the first fall in ten years (UNHCR, Global Trends, 2026).

7. Democracy, institutions and rights

- **Democratic decline:** Global freedom declined for the **twentieth consecutive year**: in 2025, 54 countries deteriorating against 35 improving (Freedom House, 2026).
- **Trust:** In OECD countries **40%** of citizens have high or moderately high trust in their national government; 43% have low or no trust (OECD, Trust Survey 2026).
- **Prisons:** In Europe, on 31 January 2025, there were on average **95.2 inmates per 100 places** (94.7 a year earlier). 14 prison systems are overcrowded, 9 of them seriously, including Italy and France (Council of Europe, SPACE I, 2026).
- **Violence against women:** About **840 million women**, almost one in three, have suffered violence from a partner or sexual violence in the course of their lives; the figure is almost unchanged since 2000 (WHO, 2025).

8. Debt, trade and aid

- **Global debt:** In 2024 it reached **251,000 billion dollars**, just above 235% of world GDP; public debt stands at 93% of GDP (IMF, Global Debt Monitor 2025).
- **Trade:** World trade exceeded **35,000 billion dollars** for the first time in 2025 (UNCTAD estimate, 2025). At the same time, geopolitical tensions are pushing towards regionalisation and the pursuit of strategic autonomy in semiconductors, energy and critical minerals (assessment).

- **Development aid:** In 2025 it fell by **23.1%**, the sharpest annual fall ever recorded, dropping to 174.3 billion dollars (OECD, preliminary data, 2026).

Part two — Overall reading

This part is an interpretation of the preceding data.

The individual phenomena cannot be addressed with isolated sectoral approaches. Read together, the data show three recurring gaps.

Between what is produced and how it is distributed. A fifth of the available food is wasted while 645 million people suffer from hunger. Productivity grows more than wages. Wealth increases and becomes concentrated.

Between what is known and what is done. Climate goals are shared, but emissions are at record levels. Military expenditure has been growing for eleven years, while development aid records its sharpest fall ever and climate adaptation receives a fraction of what is needed.

Between those who decide and those who bear the effects. Freedom has been retreating for twenty years and, in OECD countries, those who do not trust their own government outnumber those who do.

The advances reported alongside the critical issues indicate that these gaps are not inevitable: where there have been coordinated collective choices, from child health to the ozone layer, the results have come.

Sources

The links lead to the page consulted for verification, on 3 October 2026. Where the original report could not be reached, they lead to the summary used in its place.

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